



The Ideals OF INDIA

What we need is a gripping political vision that articulates the optimism and pride in Indianness

— By **SUNIL KHILNANI**

For years, standard Indian marketing strategy has been to make products desirable by projecting an aura of foreignness: shampoo foam blending into Alpine snows; New York street grit selling blue jeans; well-cut suits set against European castles. Now though, Indianness is a selling point—it is often as amusingly fictional as those Alpine peaks or Bohemian castles on the hoardings. For instance, even as General Motors was sputtering into bankruptcy in its American homeland, its Indian TV ads featured Indians surging out of a sun-roof, joyfully waving a silky Tiranga as they sped over Mumbai's J.J. flyover.

It is under an Indian flag that the world is coming to India lately. More importantly, India has become a place where Indians want to be.

This new self-belief and confidence in things Indian, and in the country, is felt especially among the young. Within the next decade, the average age of our population will be under 30, and a remarkable four-fifths of these young Indians, a CSDS survey found earlier this year, are optimistic about their future along with their children's. Against expectations, the most aspirational and optimistic youth are to be found not in the big cities, but in the small towns and villages. By a large majority, India's youth subscribe to democratic principles and freedom of expression. Among young Indians, there is a growing sense that India has to further its entry into the global domain—that self-isolation is not the way forward.

No political form or encompassing narrative

has yet emerged to draw together these valuable energies of self-worth, commitments to openness, democratic practices—and to hope about the future. Indeed, this nascent national feeling makes some uneasy. But from today's impulses could emerge a very different sense of national honour and the intellectual and political challenge is to help define this new nationalism.

Fear is often a spur to nationalism and such was the case with the Hindutva nationalism of the BJP and its Parivar. The nationalism of Hindutva was born out of an effort to appease and pander to the sentiments of a minority of Hindus, those troubled by the social and economic changes that began to agitate India in the 1990s. The BJP ideologues and leaders hoped that by playing upon such fears—those of Muslims and other minorities, fears of being left out of the economic race, fears that others were cornering social privileges—they could reap